believes that reviving abandoned industrial sites offers a less contentious and economically quicker route to industrialisation. Also, it might get involved in acquiring land for private projects on a case to case basis.

The land reforms will also include scrapping the Urban Land (Ceiling and Regulation) Act, 1976, which restricts ownership of vacant urban land in major cities. The state government argues that the law—retained by Left Front and TMC regimes—is an impediment to industrialisation. Though most states repealed it after Parliament enacted the Urban Land (Ceiling and Regulation) Repeal Act in 1999, West Bengal continued to retain it.

Takeaways

- **Recycling unused factory land seen as a quick way to industrialisation**
- **Old Urban Land Ceiling Act to be discarded, new policies framed**
- **Part of a policy reset on industry, AI, startups; complements infrastructure-heavy state budget**

TARGETED POLICY

According to Dasgupta, land initiatives form part of a broader policy reset. "We have identified around ten sectors where dedicated policy frameworks are being prepared," he says, naming a few, such as an industrial policy, an artificial intelligence policy and a startup policy.

"It will probably take a year or two before the state becomes fully infrastructure-ready for large investments," says Dasgupta. "Our effort is to ensure that when investment decisions are made, West Bengal is no longer held back by policy uncertainty, inadequate infrastructure or land constraints." Bengal's industrial wasteland awaits a midas touch. ■



FAITH AND POWER Punjab ministers and MLAs appear before the Akal Takht, Jun. 29; (below) CM Bhagwant Mann and Arvind Kejriwal at a presser a day earlier

▶ PUNJAB

THE TAKHT HAS THE LAST WORD

The Akal Takht's intervention over Punjab's anti-sacrilege law reasserts the primacy of Sikh religious authority

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

ON JUNE 29, THE AKAL TAKHT ORDERED the Punjab government to amend its controversial new anti-sacrilege law within 30 days and suspend its implementation until the changes were made. The directive followed an extraordinary hearing that brought together Punjab's Sikh political establishment in a way never seen before. Cabinet ministers, ruling and opposition MLAs, independents and assembly speaker Kultar Singh Sandhwan appeared before the Akal Takht, Sikhism's supreme seat of authority, to answer for a law—Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026—the assembly had passed unanimously in a special session on Baisakhi (April 13). Chief minister Bhagwant Mann was absent—not because of protocol, but because he had been excommunicated over an alleged sacrilege video a fortnight earlier.

The Akal Takht's directives, known as *hukumnama*, are regarded as binding by Sikhs around the world. With the assembly election due in early 2027, the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) finds itself confronting a political reality in which religious legitimacy can carry as much weight as a legislative majority.

The Mann regime has argued